

Communicating About What to Expect as Dementia Progresses

People living with dementia, and their caregivers, want information on what to expect as the disease progresses. Engaging patients and caregivers in conversations about what to expect, and connecting them with helpful resources, will improve their quality of life and enable planning for the future.

Key Takeaways

Although existing drug treatments do not change the underlying course of the disease, there are many non-pharmacological interventions that support both patients and caregivers living with dementia. When communicating about what to expect, clinicians should:

- Describe strategies that can be used to help sustain quality of life, now and in the future
- Assure patients and caregivers that you will help navigate these resources, and continue to be there for support and care throughout the disease progression
- Schedule frequent follow-ups with your patient and their caregiver(s)
- Offer specific written information (including CAPC's handout, *Dementia Care Resources for Caregivers*), and refer patients and caregivers to community resources and support services

If you are looking for additional ways to help your patients and their caregivers understand what to expect and provide support, visit the resources below.

Refer Patients

Referring patients and caregivers to Alzheimer's Association is the first step. Order the free official referral pad for making easy referrals to Alzheimer's Association, and offer patients and their caregiver(s) the **24/7 helpline number (800-272-3900)** for around-the-clock support.

act.alz.org/site/SPageServer/?pagename=Referral_Pad

Access Clinical Resources

After referring your patients to Alzheimer's Association, access the following clinical resources:

- For easy access to clinical information and assessment tools, download the Physician Pocketcard App from Alzheimer's Association
alz.org/professionals/healthcare-professionals/clinical-resources/physician_pocketcard_app
- Alzheimer's Association – Cognitive Impairment Care Planning Toolkit
alz.org/careplanning/downloads/care-planning-toolkit.pdf

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- National Institute on Aging – Alzheimer's and Dementia Resources for Professionals
nia.nih.gov/health/alzheimers-dementia-resources-for-professionals
- Alzheimer's Association – Health Care Professionals and Alzheimer's
alz.org/health-care-professionals/health-care-clinical-medical-resources.asp
- Alzheimer's Greater Los Angeles – Plain language tip sheets that you can provide caregivers, which address a variety of topics, including responding to behavioral symptoms, managing medications, driving, and toileting
alzgla.org/professionals/caregiver-tip-sheets

Connect Your Patients to Community Resources

- Alzheimer's Association – Community Resource Finder
communityresourcefinder.org
- Family Caregiver Alliance – Family Care Navigator of State-by-State Resources
caregiver.org/family-care-navigator
- U.S. Administration on Aging – Eldercare Locator
eldercare.acl.gov
- Area Agency on Aging – Access resources from your local Area Agency on Aging via the search tool on their national website
n4a.org
- National Respite Network – Respite Care Locator
archrespite.org/respitelocator
- National Adult Day Services Association – Adult Day Center Locator
nadsa.org/consumers/choosing-a-center
- Alzheimer's Association – Safe Return Program
alz.org/care/dementia-medic-alert-safe-return.asp
- Alzheimer's Association – Dementia and Driving Resource Center
alz.org/care/alzheimers-dementia-and-driving.asp
- Music and Memory
musicandmemory.org

Print or email CAPC's *Dementia Care Resources for Caregivers* handout for patients and caregivers.

This handout accompanies CAPC's course, *Communicating About What to Expect as Dementia Progresses*. Visit CAPC's online curriculum, "Best Practices in Dementia Care and Caregiver Support" for more.